Variations on the Death of Trotsky

By David Ives

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

ISE ONLY

Lights up on TROTSKY sitting at his desk, writing furiously. The handle of a mountain-climber's axe is sticking out of the back of his head

NOTE: Actress also plays the role of RAMON

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Lee Harvey Oswald, Nathuram Godse and Sirhan Sirhan comprise the most famous assassins of political figures in the 20th century.*

ACTRESS: *Oswald assassinated President Kennedy, Godse murdered Mahatma Gandi and Sirhan Sirhan killed Robert Kennedy, Right?*

ACTOR: *Right. Their murderous acts not only changed history but also guaranteed them everlasting infamy and a kind of immortality.*

ACTRESS: *However, some prominent assassins have become forgotten in the mists of time -- one of them was born 100 years ago in Barcelona, Spain.*

ACTOR: *Jaime Ramón Mercader del Río, a Spanish communist and agent for Russia's notorious intelligence agency, murdered Russian revolutionary Leon Trotsky in Mexico City in 1940 under orders from Joseph Stalin.*

ACTRESS: *Well that's not funny – I thought we were going to do a humorous duo! I don't DO drama! I told you I don't DO drama!*

ACTOR: *No worries. This is . . . . .*

TOGETHER: *David Ives' Variations on the Death of Trotsky*

VARIATION ONE

TROTSKY: *(as he writes)* The proletariat is right. The proletariat must *always* be right. And the revolution of the proletariat against oppression must go on . . . *forever*! *(MRS. TROTSKY enters, holding al large book)* And forever and forever . . . !

MRS TROTSKY: Leon, I was just reading the encyclopedia.

TROTSKY: The heading?

MRS TROTSKY: Trotsky, Leon

TROTSKY: Good, It's about me.

MRS TROTSKY: Listen to this. *(Reads)* "On August 20th, 1940, a Spanish Communist named Ramon Mercader smashed a mountain-climber's axe *(looks at the axe in Trotsky's head)* into Trotsky's skull in Coyoacan, a suburb of Mexico City. Trotsky died the next day."

TROTSKY: What is the year of that encyclopedia?

MRS TROTSKY: *(Checks the spine)* "*Insert this year's date as the response.*"

TROTSKY: Strange . . . but interesting. I *am* Trotsky. And this is our house in Coyoacan. And we have a Spanish gardener named Ramon --?

MRS TROTSKY: Mercader. Yes….

TROTSKY: Hmmm. . . What is the date today?

MRS TROTSKY: August 21, 1940.

TROTSKY: Then I'm safe! That article says it happened on the twentieth, which means it would have happened yesterday. And I'd be dead today, with . . . *(Gingerly feeling the axe in the back of his head)* . . . with a mountain-climber's axe in my skull. *(shrugs it off)* Will the capitalist press never get things right? *(resumes writing)*

MRS TROTSKY: But Leon, isn't that the handle of a mountain-climber's axe, sticking out

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of your skull?

TROTSKY: *(looks into the mirror)* It certainly does look like one . . . and you know, Ramon was in here yesterday, telling me about his mountain-climbing trip. And now that I think of it, he was carrying a mountain-climber's axe. I can't remember if he had it when he left the room . . . *(considers)* Did Ramon report to work today? *(he dies, falling face forward onto his desk)*

VARIATION TWO

(Trotsky begins to pace)

TROTSKY: This is very bad news. This is serious.

MRS TROTSKY: What is serious, Leon?

TROTSKY: *I have a mountain-climber's axe buried in my skull!*

MRS TROTSKY: Smashed, actually. It says Mercader "smashed" the axe into your skull, not "buried" --

TROTSKY: All right, all right. What am I going to do?

MRS TROTSKY: Maybe a hat would cover the handle. You know. One of those cute little Alpine hats, with a point and a feather . . . ? *(Sees the look on his face, and stops.)*

TROTSKY: The encyclopedia says that I die today? Does it say what time?

MRS TROTSKY: No.

TROTSKY: So much for the usefulness of that encyclopedia. All right, then, I have until midnight at the latest.

MRS TROTSKY: What should I tell Cook about supper?

TROTSKY: Well, she can forget the soup course. *(TROTSKY falls to the floor and dies)*

MRS TROTSKY: Nyet, nyet, *nyet*!

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VARIATION THREE

TROTSKY: But this man is a gardener. At least he's been *posing* as a gardener. Doesn't that make him a member of the proletariat?

MRS TROTSKY: I'd say so.

TROTSKY: Then what's he doing smashing a mountain-climber's axe into my skull?

MRS TROTSKY: I don't know. Have you been oppressing him?

TROTSKY: Why would Ramon have done this to me?

MRS TROTSKY: Maybe he's a literalist.

TROTSKY: A what?

MRS TROTSKY: A literalist. Maybe Ramon ran into Manuel yesterday. You now – Manuel? The head gardener? Maybe Ramon asked him, "Will Mr. Trotsky have time to look at the nasturtiums today?" And maybe Manuel said, "I don't know – axe Mr. Trotsky." HA HA HA HA HA HA HA !

TROTSKY: Very funny.

MRS TROTSKY: Or maybe he was just hot-to-trotsky.

TROTSKY: Oh, very, very funny.

MRS TROTSKY: Or maybe he just wanted to *pick your brain*! HOO HOO HEE HEE HAAA HAAA!

TROTSKY: Stop it! *Stop it!* *(He dies)*

MRS TROTSKY: HA HA HA HA HA HA HA !

VARIATION FOUR

TROTSKY: Call Ramon in here. You'd better get him quickly. I have a mountain-

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climber's axe in my skull.

MRS TROTSKY: *Ramon! Come quickly! (RAMON enters with a sombrero, serape, huaraches and a guitar)*

TROTSKY: Good morning, Ramon.

RAMON: Good morning, senor *(they shake hands)*

TROTSKY: Have a seat, please *(to audience)* You see? We have a very good employer-employee relations here. *(to Ramon)* Ramon, did you bury this mountain-climber's axe in my skull?

RAMON: I did not bury it, senor. I *smashed* it into your skull.

TROTSKY: Excuse me?

RAMON: You see? You can still see the handle. So we cannot say "buried," we can only say "smashed," or perhaps "jammed" –

TROTSKY: All right, all right. Buy *why* did you do this?

RAMON: I think I read about it in an encyclopedia.

TROTSKY: *(to audience)* The power of the printed word! (to Ramon) But why? Do you realize who I am? Do you realize that you smashed this axe into the skull of a major historical figure? I helped run the Russian Revolution! I fought Stalin! I was a major political theorist! Why did you do this? Was it political disaffection? Anti-counterrevolutionary backlash? Oh, God! What a fool I've been! *(He dies)*

VARIATION FIVE

TROTSKY: Well. All right then. The twenty-first of August 1940. The day I'm going to die. Interesting. And to think that I've gone over so many twenty-firsts of August in my life, like a man walking over his own grave. . .

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MRS TROTSKY: It's been wonderful being married to you, Leon. Though it was a burden at times, being married to a major historical figure.

TROTSKY: I'm sorry I was away from home so often, tending the revolution. . . And I'm sorry I couldn't have been more in touch with my feelings.

MRS TROTSKY: *(gentle protest)* No . . . please . . . .

TROTSKY: And that I often had such trouble expressing my emotions.

MRS TROTSKY: Oh, I haven't been everything I should have been.

TROTSKY: Well, it's a little late for regrets, with a mountain-climber's axe buried in one's skull.

MRS TROTSKY: Smashed, actually.

TROTSKY: So it wasn't old age, or even cancer that I feared for years. It was an axe wielded by a Spanish Communist posing as a gardener. The gardener was false, and yet the garden that he tended was real. How was I to know he was my killer when I passed him every day? How was I to know I'd never get to know about the bomb, or the eighty thousand dead at Hiroshima? Or rock and roll, or Gorbachev, or the state of Israel? How was I supposed to know I'd be erased from the history books of my own land . . . ?

MRS TROTSKY: But reinstated, at least partially, someday.

TROTSKY: What does that entry say? Would you read it again?

MRS TROTSKY: On August 20th, 1940, a Spanish Communist named Ramon Mercader smashed a mountain-climber's axe into Trotsky's skull in Coyoacan, a suburb of Mexico City. Trotsky dies the next day.

TROTSKY: It gives you a little hope about the world, doesn't it? That a man could have a mountain-climber's axe smashed into his skull, and yet live on for one whole day . . . ? *(Trotsky dies)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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